

Single-Seat Fighters

World War I saw tremendously rapid progress in airframe and engine technology, and in every aspect of aircraft design. As each side struggled for aerial supremacy, first one then another aircraft would briefly flourish, then wither as its leading features were either copied or beaten. Speed, agility, armaments, and strength were the key factors in successful single-seat fighter design.



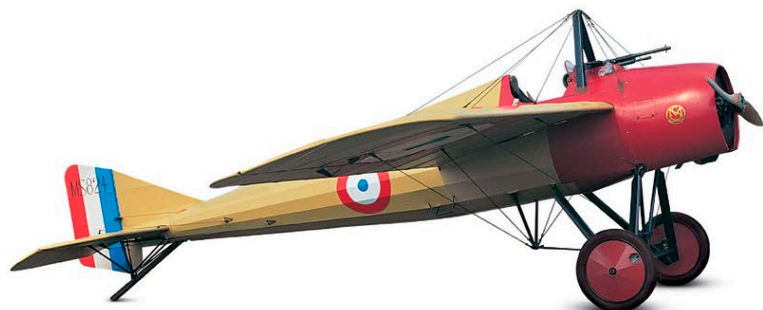
△ Fokker E.II Eindecker 1915

Origin Germany

Engine 100 hp Oberursel U.19 air-cooled 9-cylinder rotary

Top speed 87 mph (140 km/h)

Dutchman Anthony Fokker's monoplane was an improved version of the Morane-Saulnier. Fitted with a synchronizing interrupter gear for its gun, it gave Germany air superiority in late 1915.



▷ Nieuport 17 1916

Origin France

Engine 110-130 hp Gnome et Rhône 9Ja air-cooled 9-cylinder rotary

Top speed 110 mph (177 km/h)

Developed from the agile Type 11, the Nieuport 17 was the best fighter of 1916 and widely used by the Allies: it offered superior performance and agility, plus a synchronized machine gun.



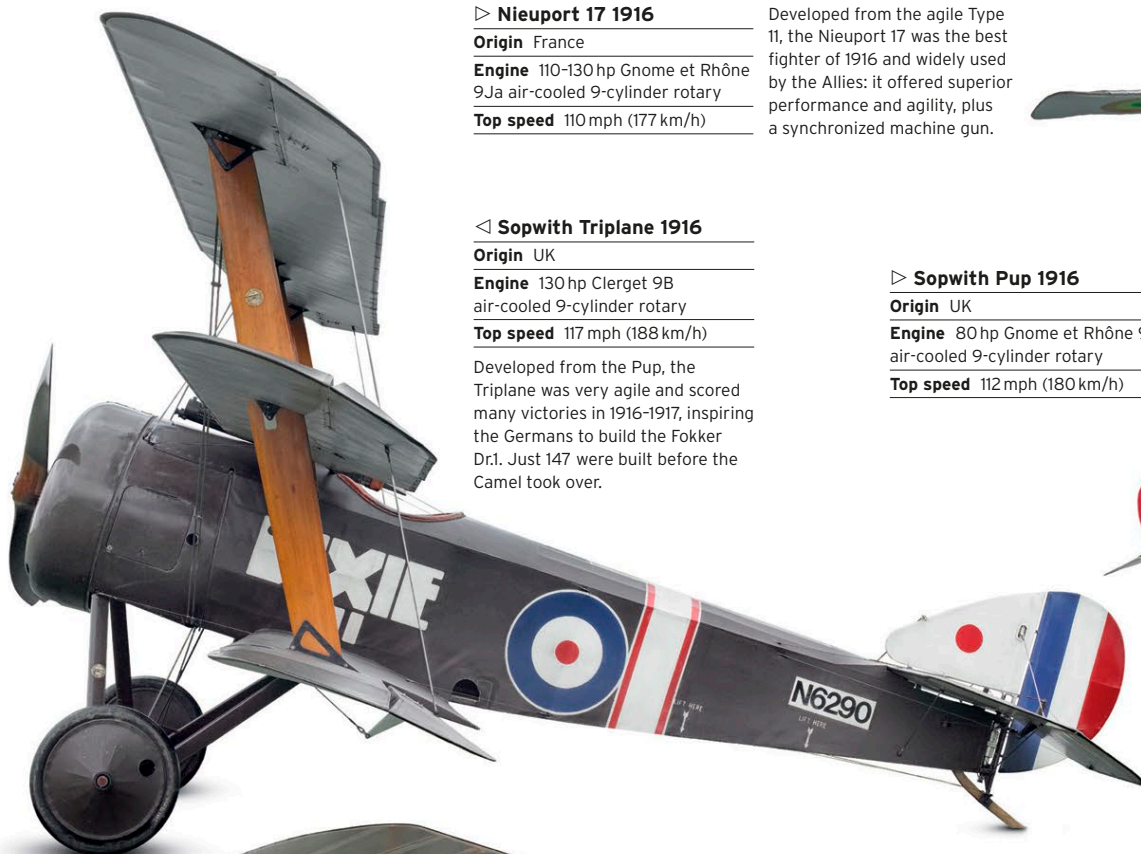
◁ Morane-Saulnier Type N 1915

Origin France

Engine 80 hp Gnome et Rhône air-cooled 9-cylinder rotary

Top speed 89 mph (144 km/h)

The Type N was fitted with Roland Garros's pioneering machine gun that fired through a propeller with steel deflector plates to prevent damage. Although effective when first built, the wing-warping aircraft was soon obsolete.



◁ Sopwith Triplane 1916

Origin UK

Engine 130 hp Clerget 9B air-cooled 9-cylinder rotary

Top speed 117 mph (188 km/h)

Developed from the Pup, the Triplane was very agile and scored many victories in 1916-1917, inspiring the Germans to build the Fokker Dr.1. Just 147 were built before the Camel took over.

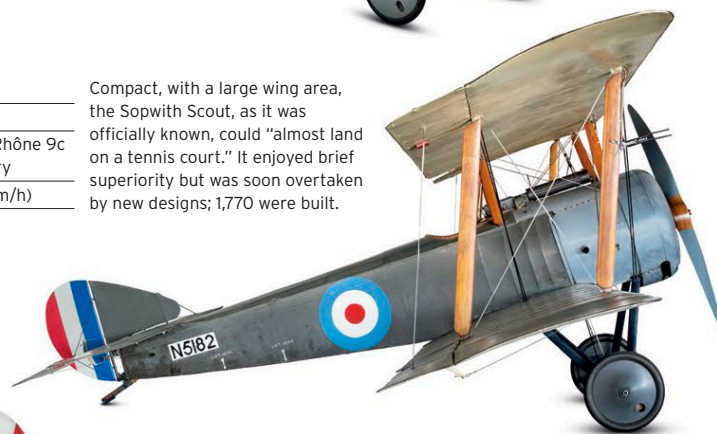
▷ Sopwith Pup 1916

Origin UK

Engine 80 hp Gnome et Rhône 9c air-cooled 9-cylinder rotary

Top speed 112 mph (180 km/h)

Compact, with a large wing area, the Sopwith Scout, as it was officially known, could "almost land on a tennis court." It enjoyed brief superiority but was soon overtaken by new designs; 1,770 were built.



▽ Sopwith F.1 Camel 1917

Origin UK

Engine 130 hp Clerget 9B/150 hp Bentley BR1 air-cooled 9-cylinder rotary

Top speed 115 mph (185 km/h)

Although difficult to fly, the highly maneuverable Camel, armed with twin machine guns, shot down more enemy aircraft than any other in WWI. Some 5,490 were built, giving Allied forces air superiority.



△ Sopwith 5F.1 Dolphin 1917

Origin UK

Engine 200 hp Hispano-Suiza 8B water-cooled V8

Top speed 131 mph (211 km/h)

Fast, maneuverable, and easy to fly, Herbert Smith's new fighter for 1917 was outstanding at high altitude, although its unusual forward-lower-wing design led to it being mistaken for a German fighter.

